St. George's Caye
The Birthplace of a Nation

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Foreword

On the 1st of June some 213 years ago, 128 men, of diverse ethnic heritage, gathered at a meeting in old Belize town to decide the fate of what was then a fledgling settlement on the east coast of Central America.

The meeting had been called in response to an impending invasion by a Spanish force that was preparing to invade the settlement by sea from the Yucatan. The intention of the meeting was for the settlers to decide whether to evacuate the settlement and leave for Jamaica, or to remain and face the wrath of the Spanish armada.

Archival documents confirm that by a majority of 14 votes our brave, but ill equipped, pioneers decided to stay and defend their settlement, and to fight what was then one of the most powerful countries of the 18th century.

A year, three months, and 10 days later, on the 10th of September 1798, 14 Spanish ships advanced on St. George's Caye, Belize's first capital. With four sloops, two schooners and 7 gun flats the make shift defense force faced off with the Spanish. The one incontrovertible aftermath of this sometimes disputed battle is that the Spanish never again attempted to reclaim the settlement for their monarchs. And whether that battle lasted 2 hours, 2 days or 2 months is truly of no real historical consequence.

In contrast, the decision of our forefathers to decline the option of retreat to Jamaica, their decision to stay and defend the fledgling settlement, and their decision to fight for the right to establish their own homeland is of paramount and consequential historical significance to all of us who call Belize our home.

It was that decision that has us speaking our own version of English rather than Spanish, It was that decision that made this

country a haven for refugees seeking freedom under the law and protection from persecution, it was that decision that bequeathed this land to us and it was that decision that gave birth to the modern and ethnically diverse nation we call Belize. That decision was truly the most defining moment in the early history of our country.

These are historical facts that should never be erased by historical revisionism. As Golda Meir once said, “One cannot and must not try to erase the past merely because it does not fit the present”. Bob Marley further reiterated this critical view when he reminded us that “In this great future you can't forget your past”.

On behalf of the National Institute of Culture and History, we present this publication for the purpose of keeping the knowledge of Belize's History alive, now, and for generations to come.

Long live Belize.

Jaime J. Awe Ph.D.

Decision Time: June 1, 1797

Nigel Encalada

Date: *June 1, 1797*
Time: *9 o'clock a.m.*
Place: *Courthouse near the Mouth of the Belize River*
Event: *Public Meeting of the Inhabitants in the Bay of Honduras*
Question to be decided upon: *"Whether this meeting do consider it most for the interest of the community at large to continue to carry on defense operations for the keeping possession of the settlement or to determine upon a general evacuation...?"*

Historical records suggest that beside the indigenous Maya the British had began settling in Belize, primarily at the mouth of the Belize River and St. George's Caye during the first half of the 17th century. Over one century later, in 1765 Sir William Burnaby arrived in the Belize and put in place the settlement's first British approved set of laws. This "constitution" became known as Burnaby's Code and was based on the settlers already established customs and practices. One key feature of the Code was that it made specific provision for the establishment of a decision making body made up of freed men, who were given the authority to elect magistrates on an annual basis. These magistrates held responsibility for the conduct of the legal and administrative affairs of the settlement. In his 1878 Report to the British Parliament, Colonial Secretary, Henry Fowler referred to this Public Meeting, which presided over the settlements affairs in the years leading up to the Battle of St. George's Caye, by saying that, "This I venture to think, was the freest constitution ever enjoyed by or granted to a British Settlement. " However, just 32 years after the introduction of Burnaby's Code, the freedom enjoyed by the settlers to administer its own affairs was put to the ultimate test. On June 1, 1797, in the face of a massive impending Spanish invasion from Yucatan, the Public Meeting was forced to vote on the question: "Whether this meeting do consider it most for the interest of the community at large to continue to carry on defence operations for the keeping possession of the settlement or to determine upon a general evacuation?"

During the 18th century a pattern was emerging where as a result of rivalry with Spain and the growing power of the United States the British were slowly being forced out of the Central American mainland. As was the case in Belize, a few British settlers had taken up residence in various parts of Central America and unlike their countrymen in the Caribbean islands; they had taken up the extraction and exportation of logwood and mahogany. These woodcutting settlements included Laguna de Términos in Campeche Mexico, the Mosquito Shore in Nicaragua and the Settlement in Belize. All three British

. . . the settlers in Belize were living in an endangered land.

settlements were exposed to Spanish harassment and efforts to have them expelled for fear of their growth into permanent settlements. As a result at the time of the vote, the settlers in Belize were living in an endangered land.

This harassment was evident in the writings of historian Roy Murray (2006), who pointed out that one such early instance of attempts to expel the British from the Central American mainland occurred in 1716 on the Campeche settlers at Laguna de Términos. In the face of the attack, the settlers retreated and rather than returning made their way southward into the New River area of Belize. One possible reason for their southward migration was that, unlike Belize, which was heavily forested and features several rivers and lagoons as natural geographical obstacles, the Campeche region was mostly flat and this made accessibility relatively easier. This meant that the Settlers in Campeche were more vulnerable to constant attacks because of its topography and proximity to large Spaniard strongholds in places like Merida.

In Belize, the settlers faced such harassment and threats from Spanish attacks in 1716, 1724, 1733, 1747, 1751 and 1779. (Shoman 2000) Here, the settlers used a "retreat and return" strategy. That is, whenever they were displaced by the Spanish they simply returned to the settlement after the Spanish had left. The fact that the Spaniards left was evidence of their disenchantment and frustration with the environmentally hostile territory in Belize. This provided the settlers with the opportunity to return on each occasion and to continue their logging operations. However, the retreat and return strategy was not always without tremendous difficulty. In September 1779, a surprise Spaniard invasion captured and destroyed St. George's Caye as well as the mainland settlement. Almost four hundred of the settlers, whites and slaves were taken captive and marched overland to Merida in Mexico and later transported and imprisoned in the dungeons of Havana, Cuba. It is interesting to note that many of the enslaved men and women were unaccounted for after this 1779 surprise attack. In fact they are no records today which suggest where they might have gone after the Spanish invasion. It was not until 1782, that those who had survived were released from prison and transported to Jamaica. Furthermore, it was not until after the 1783 Treaty of Versailles that concession was made by Spain allowing for return to the settlement of those who had survived the ordeal. This experience deeply scarred the psyche of the settlers and would feature prominently in their decision on whether to stay or evacuate the settlement given the threat of another Spanish attack.

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A variation of this retreat and return strategy also manifested itself in the British Mosquito Shore Settlements. This variation involved military resistance and counter-attacks on the Spanish troops attempting to take hold of British occupied settlements. As an example, biographer

and historian, Clifford Conner (2000) explained that in 1780 at the British settlement of Black River in Mosquitia, located along the Bay of Honduras, a Spanish attack completely sacked and destroyed the capital town of Black River. Despite the destruction of the town, the British settlers returned at the end of 1780 after the Spaniards had left. The return, though, was short lived after a Spaniard expedition from Trujillo led by Captain Tómas de Juliá again captured Black River. This time the Spaniards garrisoned the town to deter any attempts at re-settlement. This did not have its intended outcome since by 1782 a force of over 1,000 men including soldiers sent from Jamaica and led by Lieutenant Marcus Despard recaptured Black River and firmly re-established British presence. Despite the success, this campaign to maintain British presence in Central America was quickly nullified by geo-politics and diplomacy. Britain had been embattled and weakened by the American Revolution as well as by its rivalry with Spain and France. Consequently, in 1783 Britain and Spain signed the Treaty of Versailles. This treaty effectively brought hostilities to an end but had dire consequences for the British settlers in Mosquitia as Britain agreed to concede to Spain that it would evacuate the shore. The trade-off was an arrangement that allowed the evacuees to be brought to the Settlement in the Bay of Honduras. Beginning in 1786, after the signing of the London Convention, over 2,000 persons including whites, free-blacks, free-coloureds and slaves were evacuated to Belize. The gradual Spaniard eviction of British presence from the Central America mainland pushed the settlers to one of the last remaining British occupied territories: The Settlement in the Bay of Honduras. While the choke-hold of warfare and global politics had effectively ended British presence in the Mosquito shore, it had the unforeseen consequence of making the settlement in Belize more permanent due to the dramatic increase in its number of inhabitants.

By the time of the evacuation of the Mosquito Shore, the population of the "Settlement in the Bay of Honduras" had only recently begun returning after release from Cuban prisons and by 1787 had numbered approximately 700. Subsequently, the arrival of the Mosquito Shore evacuees almost quadrupled the size of the settlement. This led to the emergence of a conflict in the settlement to which Conner (2000) refers as "Baymen" and "Shoremen". This description referred to the resistance put up by the Baymen (old settlers) to the granting of land entitlements to the Shoremen (Mosquito Shore evacuees) after their arrival beginning in 1787. However, by way of Belize being the last British occupied mainland settlement in the area stretching from Mexico to Honduras and by way of their arrival, the Shoremen would eventually emerge to have equal entitlements to sit on the settlement's governing body and to have a casting vote in the decision that would have to be made at the June 1, 1797.

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Another important characteristic of the settlement was that the white settlers were largely outnumbered by African slaves and free blacks, on whom they depended for the extraction of mahogany. Though there is no specific population or census data available for the years 1796-1798, the last available data for 1790 gives an indication of the white to black ratio in the settlement. Slaves accounted for about 75% percent of the population, 14% were free blacks and free coloureds and the remaining 10% were whites. (Bolland 2003) This brings to the forefront a fact that has been largely underestimated in Belize's history. Any consideration to stay and defend the settlement depended largely on the ability of the whites to either coerce or convince their slaves to join in the defence of the settlement. Furthermore, a decision to stay depended on how the slaves viewed their place in the Belize settlement. Was it better to fight with the master they knew or side with master you didn't know? Had their previous experiences at the Mosquito Shore and the subsequent evacuation to the Belize Settlement put them in a position where, they, despite their enslavement did not want to be uprooted to live in some other place while facing an uncertain future? Belizean historian, H.F. Humphreys (2004) describes the significance of the slave population in the pending decision to stay in this way.

Any consideration to stay and defend the settlement depended largely on the ability of the whites to either coerce or convince their slaves to join in the defence of the settlement.

> *They could have deserted in total to the Spaniards, or nullified the necessity of the Spanish invasion by staging a full-scale rebellion after being armed. Instead, they bore the brunt of hardship and deprivation during the many months of the crisis with the courage that is incomprehensible in view of their pre and post battle bad treatment.*

By March, 1796 word had arrived in the settlement that a military force was being amassed with the specific objective of expelling the settlers from the Belize settlement. Unlike 1779 where they were attacked and caught by surprise the news of a pending invasion provided the settlers with an opportunity to decide on how to proceed. One immediate response to the threat came in the form a letter sent Lord Balcarres, Governor of Jamaica, requesting assistance in the form or troops, guns and ammunition. This initial request suggested that they were prepared to take up a defensive strategy depending on the support coming from Jamaica. However, it also appears that they were also prepared to leave the defence of the settlement entirely up to British Crown at the moment they felt any sense of safety and possibly because it was in their economic interest instead to employ themselves in the woodcutting camps. The H.M.S. Merlin arrived in the settlement commanded by Lieutenant Thomas Dundass and brought muskets and ammunition to aid

the defence preparations. However, historian H.F. Humphreys makes the observation that once Dundass requested that the settlers employ the use of their slaves for the defence of the settlement, he found them reluctant to do so and they instead sent the slave workers into inland woodcutting camps. Humphreys (2004) gives the opinion that "This was the beginning of a long pattern of unruly conduct…"

The "unruly conduct" to which Humphreys refers was indeed only part of the problem that the settlement would face in dealing with the decision to stay or evacuate the settlement. By December 31, 1796 Colonel Barrow arrived in the settlement and was named Commander-in-Chief and Superintendent of the Honduras Settlement. He immediately set about set about preparing the settlers by providing basic military training. However, by January, 1797 he also noted concerns to Lord Balcarres about a lack of provisions in the settlement. Furthermore, panic was raised when Colonel Barrow was informed of nearby hostilities resulting in Spanish capture of British vessels. By February 11, 1797 the Public Meeting itself passed a resolution that the "whole effective force of the Settlement should be immediately brought forward" and that martial law be declared. Indeed, the declaration of martial meant that all economic activity within the settlement was brought to a standstill. Only two and a half months later in a letter dated May 1, 1797, forty-two of the settlers realizing that military troops were not immediately available sent a Letter to Barrow suggesting that assistance be sought from the troops on the Island of Rattan.

The settlers found themselves facing difficult circumstances. Most of the settlers would have preferred that defence of the settlement be undertaken by the British Crown. Few settlers, including the Chairman of the Public Meeting, Thomas Potts, still had lingering memories of their 1779 capture and imprisonment and did not have any desire to again become victims to Spanish force. They were also concerned about the uncertainty of the preparations and the loss of income that would result from a sustained effort to remain vigilant and prepared to undertake the defence of the settlement. The lack of food provisions, adequate supplies of artillery, muskets and ammunition presented them with what was altogether a situation in which they would have to make a decision. It was a decision that would help to decide on the future course of action to take in regards to the future of the settlement.

After nearly a century of deliberate attempts to expel the settlers and the settlers themselves having been fore-warned of the pending invasion, the Public Meeting was called to decide on the fate of the settlement. On a meeting held on May 31, 1797, the records of the Public Meeting show that given the gravity of a question to be asked of its members that a separate meeting be called at 9 on the morning of Thursday, June 1, 1797. What occurred on that fateful day was the largest Public Meeting in the history of the settlement. Among the attendees were the whites who dominated the membership of the Public Meeting. Also in attendance would have been a few free blacks and free coloureds that were in possession of sufficient wealth and

property that allowed them to sit and vote in the Public Meeting.
The record shows that at the start of the meeting 94 persons were in attendance. The clerk of the meeting Mr. George Tompson recorded that:

> *After much conversation and several of the gentlemen having communicated their sentiments respecting the critical situation of this settlement and the best mode to be adopted for the general good.*
> *The Chairman put the following question*
> *Whether this meeting do consider it most for the interest of the community at large to carry on defensive operations for the keeping possession of the settlement or to determine upon a general evacuation through the medium of His Majesty's Superintendent and Captain Dundas as soon as the same can be carried into execution.*
> *Upon casting the names there appeared for the evacuation fifty one against it Sixty five, Majority against the general evacuation fourteen.*

The fact that the decision to stay was carried by a margin of only fourteen votes was indicative of the difficult nature of the question posed to the inhabitants. However, the die was cast and the settlers with help from Jamaica would go on to successfully defend the settlement. The Rest is History.

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The Battle of St. George's Caye

Howard F. Humphreys

On 5th December, 1796, HMS "Merlin," a sixteen-gun sloop of war commanded by Lieutenant Thomas Dundas, dropped anchor in the harbor south-east of Haulover Creek where the hub of the "British Settlement in the Bay of Honduras had been relocated from St. George's Caye.[1] *Shortly thereafter, The Spaniards commenced yet another round of anti-British hostilities with the capture of two schooners and a sloop in the Bay of Honduras."*[2] *Dundas retaliated by capturing "the commander of their depredatory squadron,"*[3] *most likely aboard the armed vessel "Incarnation" which was eventually moored at the mouth of the Belize River. These were the opening salves of the conflict that would erupt over twenty months later with the final confrontation near St. George's Caye, thus closing the century-long Anglo-Spanish duel over the British Settlement in the Bay of Honduras.*

More than a hundred years earlier, St. George's Caye had attracted the first British settlers in the Bay of Honduras despite Spanish claims to the region. The Spaniards called it 'Cay Casina' or Cosinas. By 1695 the first reliably documented naval assault against the British pirates-turned-logwood cutters targeted the "enemy pirates at the site of Cosinas, where they had infested the waters."[4] "Even though the attack itself appears to have been successful in driving away their "enemy pirates," the Spaniards made no attempt to occupy the island, and as soon they left the "pirates" returned. This 'infestation' of British pirates-turned-settlers which rankled the Spaniards not only survived; it grew, fostered in part by the settlers' "retreat and return" strategy described in Nigel Encalada's illuminating article.

Growth of the settlement continued to defy Spain's wrath, manifested in several other 18th century attacks including the destruction of the settlements on St. George's Caye and the mainland in 1779, well treated in both articles. Sufficient here to add that re-settlement, and the subsequent arrival of the Mosquito Shore evacuees not only led to "a shift both in the locus of government and the pattern of settlement from St. George's Cay to the Belize River,"[5] but also infused the Settlement with new blood that proved to be critical in the outcome of the final confrontation near St. George's Caye. This confrontation was sparked by Spain's declaration of war against England on October 7, 1796. Perpetually displeased with the British presence in the Honduras Settlement, the Spanish Royal Court issued orders "para una expulsion immediata y eficaz de los colonos…." [for an immediate and effective expulsion of the colonists].[6]

Despite permitting timber extraction in Honduras, as stated by the Treaties of Paris and Versailles, Spain did not want any British presence in Central America. The successful 1779 invasion strengthened the Spaniards' conviction that the time had come to complete the "effective expulsion" of their "most resolute enemy" from the Yucatan. Effectively cut off from their

old refuge at the Mosquito Shore, the settlers faced the most serious threat to their survival, and were forced to turn to England for help as the Spaniards started "warlike preparations… in the neighbourhood." [7]

Governor Balcarres of Jamaica responded to the Magistrates' plea for help by dispatching HMS "Merlin", fresh from England, with a consignment of 1,500 muskets and ammunition. Next he made another crucial decision in selecting Major Thomas Barrow to revive the dormant, previously ineffective office of the Superintendent.

Barrow proved to be an excellent choice for the outstanding leadership role he played. Upon learning about the outbreak of hostilities, Barrow announced his commissions as Superintendent and Commander-in-Chief. He began to whip the "most notorious lawless set of miscreants" into a cohesive defense force as quickly as possible since a Spanish invasion was expected to come at any time, and the self-styled 'Principal Inhabitants were prepared to defend their homeland only until reinforcements arrived. Hence during the first six months of 1797 the Settlement was engulfed in its most strenuous ordeal since 1779: the Principal Inhabitants were pitted against Barrow to keep their grip on the Settlement; Baymen were pitted against Baymen over the question of evacuation; and all were caught in the pitiless grip of anticipating a Spanish invasion that could be totally devastating given the inadequacy of the military supplies sent from Jamaica, and the depletion of food and other necessities as a consequence of imposing martial law.

Worsening conditions, the presence of a single, relatively small battleship (HMS 'Merlin' was in essence a 'miniature frigate'), and the seeming end of any further support from Jamaica led to panic when early intelligence about Spanish preparations confirmed that "two frigates, two brigs, and some other small craft from Havana were to cooperate with three thousand land forces from Bacalar and some gun boats."[8] In those circumstances there emerged a powerful pro-evacuation faction centred around perennial Magistrate and Chairman of the Public Meeting, Thomas Potts, who was "respected and beloved by his friends and venerated as the father of the community."[9] An anti-evacuation faction drew inspiration from Irishman Thomas Paslow who

> *stood out in his uncompromising position against evacuation. He thought that those who were willing to evacuate the settlement should be made to do so, for 'the man who will not defend his Country is not entitled to reap the benefit thereof.*[10]

With such sentiments running very high, evacuation loomed large on the hostile horizon. On Thursday, June 1, 1797, the two factions squared off "at perhaps the most momentous Public Meeting and certainly one of the most well attended… in their jagged existence."[11] The outcome, as shown by Nigel Encalada's article, was the decision to stand and fight swung by a slim majority of fourteen comprised of the famous "Flowers Bank free blacks." Had the

decision been otherwise, there would have been no battle.

Yet the momentous decision to stand and fight did not terminate the most trying times of January to June, 1797. The next six months continued to severely test the resolve of even those sixty-five "gallant spirits" who would not yield to the worsening tempest. Two weeks after the decision, Dundas wrote that the situation had become "disagreeable in the extreme."[12]

On 16th December, 1796, not long after his arrival, he had described the Principal Inhabitants as "a set of merchants of different nations whose morals are not of the nicest texture, and whose interests are very different."[13] Seven months later he commented that from 16th January, 1797, when the inhabitants had sent their 'Memorial' to Balcarres, pledging to defend the Settlement and requesting assistance, but received no reply:

> *No people in the world could exert themselves more than they did, by erecting four different forts, building barracks sufficient to hold between two and three hundred soldiers all at their own expense and with their own Negroes… Owing to the collected state they have been in for these six months past, their plantations have been neglected and those of the New River totally deserted. The season has been remarkably dry. The vegetable bread [bread fruit] the black people use is scarce and cannot be got. The only provisions in the Settlement is that lately arrived in the 'Mary' which is to feed the Inhabitants and His Majesty's Sloop under my Command, as the Naval Contractors at Jamaica have not sent any supplies since my arrival here. Famine and all its attendant consequences must ensue unless we are reasonably supplied from that quarter. Should the Spaniards attack us in our present state, I dread the consequences…*[14]

Barrow's summary of the situation was equally grim:

> *Famine had already made its approaches and the situation of the country was deplorable beyond description. In addition to this scarcity of food the middling and poorer classes of people and the slaves, from being unable to supply themselves from the fruit of their labour, which was entirely applied to Military Duty and the erection of Works of Defence, are now almost naked.*[15]

The fortuitous arrival of the armed schooner "Montego Bay" escorting the transport ship "Mary" with supplies from Jamaica on 16th June relieved the siege to a small degree. Aboard the "Mary" were "provisions for one thousand men for three months."[16] Fears of mass desertions by the suffering slaves did not materialize.

Even more significantly, on 28th August Balcarres informed Barrow that he would give the settlement "every protection" he could. He was "sending an armed vessel the 'Brutus' with two transports containing provisions for 1,000 men for six months, and in three months' time would send another cargo."[17] Three companies of the 2nd Regiment, Irish Brigade, sixty men of the 83rd Regiment, totaling over 200 troops, were also being sent.[18]

On 2nd September Balcarres at last responded to the inhabitants' 'Memorial' when he reassured "The Settlers at Honduras Bay" that he had "sent three companies of infantry, some artillery and ammunition and six months provisions for 1,200 men."[19]

Somewhat heartened by Balcarres's long-anticipated reply, on 16th September the Principal Inhabitants resolved that "good understanding and perfect union of sentiment and of action between this community and His Majesty's Superintendent" was necessary because of the "most serious consideration of the present state of the Settlement."[20] With some justification, the actions of the inhabitants were not always calculated to fulfill this resolution.

Thus conflict in 1797 crested to crisis and final confrontation in 1798. The "trying time" of 1797 "was the period in which the British settlement decided to fight and not to run, a decision necessary before there could be the Battle of St. George's Cay."[21] Barrow and the usually self-centered Principal Inhabitants had established a working relationship absolutely necessary for the survival of both the office of Superintendent and the settlement itself. For the first time His Majesty's Superintendent and Commander-in-Chief was an accepted and respected part of the rudimentary system of government. Barrow's military competence and steadfast resistance to any encroachment on his authority were beginning to earn the degree of cooperation from the inhabitants that the Superintendent needed to effectively defend the settlement.

Nevertheless, the odds in favor of survival remained desperately slim, even when three companies of the 6th (Black) West India Regiment arrived in January, 1798. Barracks were constructed by the slaves at Newtown to house them.[22] After consulting with the Superintendent, a 19th January Public Meeting agreed to the deployment of four look-out boats, each with a dorey and a crew of ten men. Two boats, one to the north, one to the south, would always be out. An appropriation of 100 pounds sterling from the public purse financed this operation.[23]

Unknown to the inhabitants, on 24th February, 1798 Barrow proposed to Balcarres an offensive operation against the Spaniards at Bacalar.[24] Even the old warrior was getting tired of waiting for the Spaniards to come. Balcarres emphatically rejected this idea, stating that "nothing can be further removed from the minds of His Majesty's Ministers…than any offensive operation whatsoever."[25] Barrow was therefore instructed to "remain upon the defensive" and not to "take any step that may tend to irritate the Spaniards."[26]

Part of the Superintendent's growing impatience was induced by the constant strain of insufficient supplies. Faced with ever dwindling resources, especially since the arrival of the troops, "Barrow took matters in his own hands and bought needed military and civilian supplies from the United States of America although such trade was illegal for a British Settlement. Using the Baymen's mahogany as payment, large amounts of flour, butter and wine were purchased from the Americans..."[27] Yet despite the crucial political and military leadership role that Barrow played, he was not a naval officer, a deficiency which could not be remedied by Captain Dundas aboard the *"Merlin"* awaiting the arrival of the Spanish armada.

In accordance with the Spanish Court's directive to destroy the Honduras Settlement, in October, 1796 Field Marshal Don Arturo O'Neil Tirone, Governor and Captain-General of Yucatan, received explicit and strict orders to immediately and effectively expel the Baymen trespassers.[28] Much to O'Neil's dismay, "immediata y eficaz" would eventually mean almost two years before his combined naval and ground forces could be assembled. With great zeal he dedicated himself to the preparation of "una magnifica expedicion"[29] for which no costs were spared, and with which O'Neil, motivated no doubt by his Irish dislike for all things British, "had hoped to attack the Baymen at the very beginning of the British-Spanish hostilities, before the settlement had time to build up its strength."[30] One Irishman, Thomas Paslow was willing to sacrifice himself in defense of his adopted homeland. Another was Spain's zealously willing instrument for the annihilation of the Honduras Settlement.

By early August, 1798, two Spanish deserters gave Barrow a detailed description of O'Neil's "magnificent expedition" which had grown considerably from the four warships and 3,000 land forces mentioned by the first intelligence report in May, 1797:

> *...Two very large frigates, an armed brig, and two sloops carrying two 100 pounders, and four gunboats carrying each a 24 pounder in the bow, with several other armed vessels, arrived...at Campeachy, and taking aboard about 300 troops, then sailed and (made a rendezvous) at the island of Cozumel;...the two frigates and the brig left the fleet there and as the deserters understood, returned to La Vera Cruz...A schooner of 22 guns, to which they (the deserters) belonged, then became commodore...All the small vessels of the fleet were to be sent to Bacalar to assist in embarking the troops at that place, said to consist of 12 companies of 100 men each...Much discontent prevails in the fleet...the desertions have been great at every place where they have touched, that many are in irons, and all the common men averse to the service...*[31]

Barrow and the Baymen did not know that even a Captain, Don Sancho de Luna, defected from the "magnificent expedition" taking with him the largest

battleship, the 40-gun "Minerva," to Vera Cruz.[32] Captain Don Tello Maintella was just as insubordinate when he sailed for Cozumel aboard the second largest battleship, the 32-gun "O."[33] Compared to the mere sixteen six-pounders on the *"Merlin's"* gun deck, the combined firepower of the "Minerva" and the "O" would have been devastating. Their loss was a serious blow to O'Neil's "magnificent expedition" as in the final confrontation *"Merlin"* dominated the sea of battle.

Added to this setback was considerable delay caused by the troops' overland march from Merida to embarkation points at Bacalar. Then yellow fever began to gnaw through the rank-and-file of the Spanish troops stuffed into the close quarters of the *flota* which, when it finally reached Caye Chapel, consisted of:

> *Two thousand soldiers...embarked, and distributed in proportion to the dimensions of the vessels...*
>
> *The vessels which made the attack, in number.....9*
>
> *Reserve of equal force.....5*
>
> *A large sloop of equal force, and six schooners, not so large, but armed in the same manner as those which came down to the attack, and drawing too much water, remained with the transports and victuallers.....7*
>
> *Transports, victuallers, etc., all carrying bow and side guns of different calibers.....11*
>
> *Total.....32*
> *And navigated by five hundred seamen, principally from the Havana and Campeachy.*[34]

Thirty-two warships carrying enough "heavy metal" to level the settlement, five hundred seamen, and 2,000 troops made the armada truly awesome, but O'Neil's "magnificent expedition" was magnificent in size only. Both its firepower and morale were severely compromised by desertion, by disease, and by the poor leadership of its architect who was singularly impotent in dealing with the treasonous behavior of officers and rank-and-file alike. Although O'Neil held the title of "Field -Marshal in the armies of Spain,"[35] his post of Governor and Captain-General of Yucatan made him a glorified civil administrator woefully lacking in the naval expertise required for the mission he had been tasked with, and which he so zealously pursued. He became so obsessed with the herculean task of assembling the armada that he committed the first of several tactical blunders by not selecting a seasoned naval officer to take charge of the expedition, "both for the knowledge and

the leadership capabilities that such a person could have provided for the attack force."[36]

Barrow's intelligence regarding the actual strength of the armada gave little comfort to the pro-evacuation faction in the settlement, for the size was nonetheless formidable and alarming. If *"Merlin"* remained the sole defensive battleship, it was badly outnumbered and outgunned. From January, 1798, look-out boats took up station north of the settlement to keep close watch on the expedition's movements, while Barrow pushed ahead with land-based preparations. Clearly though, the best defense was to deny the advancing armada the chance to even land its superior number of troops. For this a better naval commander than Captain Dundas was needed to complement Barrow's contributions. He arrived in the person of Captain John Ralph Moss.

Vice Admiral Sir Hyde Parker recalled Captain Dundas to Jamaica; he departed from Honduras on 16th June aboard the armed schooner "Barbara." Vice Admiral Parker bestowed command of the *"Merlin"* upon Captain Moss, whose promotion was well received by the Principal Inhabitants. On 13th June Moss wrote to the Magistrates thanking them "for their congratulations on his appointment to command the ship destined for the defence of the Settlement and their expression of confidence, and promising his utmost efforts on their behalf."[37]

Moss proved to be a brilliant naval strategist and master mariner with sufficient steel in his spine to complete the transformation of the rag-tag band of Baymen into a credible sea-borne fighting force. He worked extremely well with Barrow, as together "they used their authority under martial law to enforce their preparations,"[38] particularly the construction of gun-flats. Moss soon drew criticism for what appeared to be frequent fishing trips which were in fact reconnaissance missions to know the location of every caye, reef, shoal and channel that had to be factored into an effective defensive strategy one which ultimately succeeded. There can be no doubt about the competence, dedication and gallantry these two military officers.

Joseph Toney must likewise be listed in the roll-call of "gallant spirits." He was a turtle fisherman whose vote against evacuation on 1st June, 1797, helped to determine the fate of his homeland. A little over a year later, his indomitable spirit was once again pressed into service aboard his turtle boat on the high seas outside the barrier reef far to the north of Honduras where he kept watch for the advancing armada. On 20th May, 1798, the armada had weighed anchors and set sails for the long voyage from Campeche to the Bay of Chetumal on the opposite (Caribbean) side of the Yucatan Peninsula. Joe Toney spotted the thirty-two warships off Cozumel cleaving a foamy wake southward bound, and on 18th July reported that position, thereby giving the settlement ample time to complete preparations.[39]

Two days later, a Public Meeting resolved

> *To bring forward and embody the whole of the effective strength of the country for its general defence, the nature of*

> *such effective strength shall comprehend white men, freed men of colour, free Negroes and Negro and other slaves capable of bearing arms.*[40]

In addition to the 1st June, 1797 no-evacuation stand, this resolution was of paramount importance and was a decisive factor in the outcome of the crisis. The Honduras Settlement could not have been successfully defended without the help of at least 1,200 adult male slaves, a fact which all the Principal Inhabitants realized when they passed the resolution and later acknowledged in writing. Unfortunately their names were never recorded, nor were their individual brave deeds. It is possible that slaves named in a 1790 census Congo Will, Guinea Sam, Eboe Jack, Mongola Sam, Mundingo Pope, and Corromontee Tom survived until 1798 to do their share in the battle. [41] More research is needed to verify this.

Certainly the slaves proved themselves more gallant than many of their masters, especially those such as Tom Potts and ex-Superintendent Lawrie who favored evacuation and continued to do so right up to 20th August, 1798. Barrow and Moss were the 'brains' and leadership of the defense; the slaves were the sinews that saved the settlement. From December, 1796, seventy slaves were already armed and guarding the settlement; [42] even more performed this arduous task for the duration of the conflict. Their resilience during all the harrowing hardships of 1797-98 earned Dundas's admiration for being "the best and strongest" he ever saw.[43] Without murmur or complaint they constructed forts/batteries, barracks, gun-boats; wooded and watered the *"Merlin;"* tended the troops. They participated in Barrow's constant drills. As a result of severe scarcity of food and other essentials, they went hungry and "almost naked." They could have deserted to the Spaniards, or rebelled after being armed. Instead they bore the brunt of hardship and deprivation during many months of crisis with a courage that is incomprehensible in the light of the degradation synonymous with slavery before and after the battle. During the battle itself, their "gallant spirits" would again be severely tested.

Next day, 21st July, another Public Meeting resolved that "a certain place or places be appointed on the River Belize where the women and children may be removed to for greater safety."[44] Captain Moss considered the almost daily meetings, the slow pace of putting into effect his written proposals for fitting out gun-boats, and delays in completing other preparations unsatisfactory. He fired a stinging letter to the Magistrates berating their "tardiness, want of unanimity, and promptness in putting the Settlement, in that state of defence it is capable of receiving, and the exigency of the present times requires."[45] He suggested a way to strengthen the forts, asserted that "the flats may be fitted in two days to receive guns…the slaves must be called down and…many other precautions…must be put in practice without delay…"[46] The Magistrates had until 8:00 a.m. the following day, 22nd July, to reaffirm their determination in writing,

> *And should a want of unity prevail where all ought to be united I assure that H.M.S. ["Merlin"] after receiving King's Officers and such of the Inhabitants on board that have shown zeal on this and other occasions shall be got under way and leave you to your fate.*[47]

Without the 16 six-pounder cannons on the gun deck of the *"Merlin,"* the fate of the settlement would surely have been annihilation by the approaching armada. Moss' threat struck home like a full broadside from those six-pounders, and effectively bolstered the 1st June, 1797 decision to stand and fight. Even though as late as 20th August Tom Potts and 52 of his cowardly followers wrote a letter to Barrow requesting evacuation "either to the island of Jamaica, or to the Bahama Islands,"[48] the majority rallied to Moss's call. Dundas had lacked the acumen and presence necessary to deal effectively with such characters as Potts and his cohorts until they met the likes of Captain John Ralph Moss.

On 26th July martial law was re-imposed. Agreeing with one of the better suggestions made by the Magistrates, on 9th August Barrow instructed Moss to destroy all the buildings owned by seventeen of the Principal Inhabitants on St. George's Caye, valued at 2,650 pounds Jamaican currency, as the island

> *"in its present deserted and defenseless state is in danger of being taken possession by the enemy, who in that event would be possessed of comfortable cover for themselves and magazines and thereby be at liberty to distress us at their leisure."*[49]

For the sixth and final time in the century-old Anglo-Spanish duel over the Honduras Settlement, St. George's Caye was engulfed in flames.

At the same time the slaves forged ahead with the construction of gun-flats, for which Moss gave "much assistance by the artificers belonging to his ship in fitting them out."[50] The sloops and schooners were armed. The entire flotilla consisted of:

> *HMS "Merlin" - sloop of war; length 106 feet; beam 28 feet; draft 11 ½ feet; armament 16 six-pounders on the gun deck, 4 twelve-pounders on the quarter deck; 2 twelve-pounders on the forecastle deck; crew 122.*
>
> *Two Sloops, "Towser" and "Tickler" one 18-pounder and 25 men each.*
>
> *One Sloop, "Mermaid" one short nine-pounder and 25 men; length of each sloop 48 feet; beam 15 feet; draft 5 feet.*

Two Schooners, "Swinger" and "Teazer," 6 four-pounders and 25 men each; length 45 feet; beam 12 feet; draft 5 feet.

Seven Gun-Flats, one 9-pounder and 16 men each; length 36 feet; beam 11 feet; draft 2 ½ feet.[51]

In addition there were about 700 troops "of all colours and descriptions" who, after the grueling months of preparation and anticipation, were ready for battle.

One historian has erroneously characterized this curious assortment of one dedicated battleship, two schooners and three small sloops bearing odd names, and seven logwood flats or 'scows' converted into gun-boats as "downright laughable."[52] When put to the test, however, they proved to be deadly serious adversaries for the lumbering, deep-draft Spanish behemoths. As will be shown, Moss's brilliant battle plan made maximum use of the shoals over which gun-boats, sloops and schooners maneuvered with ease, powered by the wind and the sinews of the slaves who manned the oars or 'sweeps.' The low-profiled, agile flotilla hammered the high, bulky Spanish ships from which the trajectory of cannon balls could not inflict direct hits. Factor into this the 8 six-pounder broadsides of the *"Merlin"* and the flotilla was no laughing matter for the Spaniards.

Nor was it a laughing matter for Thomas Paslow, who, with an eye to posterity, recorded with flawed grammar on 24th August, 1798, his share, and that of his slaves, in creating a flotilla that made the Spaniards weep:

> *At this time and ever since the commencement of Martial Law, my negroes has been employed, as much for the general good as those of any other man whatever. They have been employed assiduously in getting my scow ready which I have intended to act as gun boat and ever since the adoption of gun boats, they have been destin'd to man my own, this they have done with the approbation of the Commander in Chief and Captain Moss.*[53]

So it was that Paslow commanded one of the improvised, but highly effective gun-boats, manned by the slaves. The other six gun-boats were likewise manned by slaves and free blacks under the command of white and free colored inhabitants who gallantly faced the Dons. Equally gallant was Asa Hosmer, captain of the "Tickler," and Matthew Gelston, captain of the "Towser." Both mariners were "masters of merchant-vessels, who, with some of their crews, volunteered the business in a very handsome manner."[54] Captain Edwards of the sloop "Happy Return" described Hosmer as "an American who had lost his vessel on a reef. When the attack was threatened, he solicited and obtained the command of a flat."[55] On 30th August Captain Moss had assigned the "Tickler" to a "Captain Potts," but, according to

Barrow, Hosmer was at the helm of "Tickler" to engage the enemy during the final battle.[56] This courageous volunteerism of shipwrecked American sailors stands in sharp contrast to the rotten morale of "all the common men averse to the service" aboard the Spanish armada.

Since Joe Toney's report on 18th July, lookout boats shadowed O'Neil's awesome armada from Cozumel to the Bay of Chetumal which the warships reached on 28th July. There the troops who had marched overland from Merida embarked, and the ships headed to Caye Chapel inside the barrier reef. By 3rd September anchors splashed into the shallow sea under (to leeward of) Caye Chapel just 16 miles north-northeast of the Honduras Settlement, or about 8 miles north of St. George's Caye. This choice of anchorage was yet another of the strategic blunders, including the many months taken to assemble the "magnifica expedicion," committed by O'Neil and his rather inept, insubordinate Captain of the Fleet, Don Francisco de Fuentes de Bocanegra. All 32 vessels "were of an ocean-going variety…not built for the shallow waters within the Belizean barrier reef."[57]

The Field Marshal was no naval expert and consequently was totally out of his depth in organizing such a complicated, long-distance, sea-borne strike force faced with penetrating hazardous coastal waters before even reaching its target. Having neither knowledge nor accurate charts of Belizean coastal waters, O'Neil and Bocanegra crammed their 32-ship "magnificent expedition" into a shallow corridor 8 miles long from north (Caye Chapel) to south (St. George's Caye), barely a mile across, with the barrier reef to the east, a practically impenetrable maze of mangrove cayes and shoals to the west, and, at its southern end, funneled into an exceedingly narrow channel east of St. George's Caye. Perhaps more enlightened, cooperative leadership of the expedition would have resulted in the selection of a less disadvantageous sea of battle, but friction between O'Neil and Bocanegra only compounded further blunders.

All of this benefitted the settlement. So too did the "most cordial co-operation" between Barrow and Moss, who was praised by his land-based counterpart as "an officer of very great merit."[58] In fact, unlike O'Neil and Bocanegra, both were gallant officers "of very great merit": they welded free men and slaves into a cohesive fighting force, then planned and executed a superb defensive strategy, the linchpin of which was the *"Merlin"* and its support flotilla of shallow-draft vessels; reliable intelligence; superior knowledge about the sea of battle; and fierce, motivated warriors whites, "free men of color," free blacks and slaves all fighting for survival.

Execution of the Barrow/Moss defensive strategy commenced even before the armada dropped anchors at Caye Chapel. Information about the armada's voyage, gathered from spies, Spanish deserters and look-outs permitted Barrow to boast to his superiors that "the enemy was so well watched by scout boats and canoes that not a single movement could be made by him without our knowledge."[59] That foreknowledge enabled the defenders to correctly deploy the sloop "Towser," captained by Matthew Gelston, the

shipwrecked American sailor who volunteered to put his life in harm's way; and the schooners "Swinger" and "Teazer" to guard the channels leading to St. George's Caye, from which it was a short run north to Montego Caye, where the first skirmish erupted.[60]

On 3rd September, "the enemy endeavoured to force a passage over Montego Key Shoal with five vessels, two of which carried heavy metal [cannons], but were repulsed,"[61] thanks to the quick and effective interception by the three guardians of St. George's Caye. At home on the shallow sea, the sloop and two schooners harried the lumbering Spanish warships until they retreated to the rest of the *flota* anchored under Caye Chapel. When Moss and Barrow received news of this opening skirmish, they immediately deployed six of the gun-boats to reinforce the three guardians with vessels suited to engage the Spaniards in their futile and fool-hardy attempts at crossing their behemoths over Montego Caye Shoal. The enemy was obviously trying to access the inner channel between the cayes and the mainland in order to land troops as quickly as possible. Moss and Barrow knew that they had to prevent this from happening, otherwise the settlement would fall before the superior number of Spanish troops.

On 4th September the blocking strategy yielded more success for the defenders, including the American Captain, Asa Hosmer, "who solicited and obtained the command of a flat [gun-boat], and in a creek he sustained at one time an action against five of the Spanish gun-boats."[62] The Spaniards again committed the same tactical blunder as the day before by trying to ram five ships over the shallow seas at Montego Caye Shoal. The defenders "beat them off with great ease, and the five vessels returned to the main body of the fleet."[63]

The Spaniards had also been very busy trying to mark out a channel through the maze of creeks at Montego Caye. The departure of the five attackers gave the defenders "an opportunity of drawing and destroying the beacons and stakes, which the enemy had placed in this narrow and crooked channel, and without the use of which nothing but vessels of a very easy draught of water [could] pass."[64]

On 5th September, for the third consecutive day the Spaniards attempted to force a passage over Montego Caye Shoal with "six of their heaviest vessels…by putting their provisions and stores into other vessels."[65] The ships were accompanied by "a number of launches" and this time the firefight was furious, for the Spaniards "were repulsed, apparently with loss. On this, as well as on the two preceding days, the Spaniards expended an immense quantity of ammunition to no manner or purpose."[66] On the other hand, Barrow praised the defenders who "fired comparatively little, but with a steadiness which surpassed [his] most sanguine hopes."[67]

Having thwarted all the Spanish efforts to break through Montego Caye, Moss made yet another brilliant tactical move:

"I now clearly saw that their next effort would be to get possession of St. George's Key, from which place (only nine miles from Belize) they might go

down through the different channels leading to it, and continue to harass the Inhabitants and destroy the town at their leisure, and drive me from my anchorage there. This determined me to gain the Key before them, if possible: I therefore left Belize on the evening of the 5th." [68]

The draft of the *"Merlin"* required first sailing south-east to English Caye channel which gave a safe exit east to the deep blue beyond the barrier reef, followed by a northward passage to the channel through the reef east of St. George's Caye. In a fine feat of seamanship, Moss:

> *arrived at St. George's Key about noon on the 6th of September. The Spaniards, having found the leeward channels impracticable, had got under weigh on the morning of that day with their whole fleet, seemingly with a view of forcing a passage through the windward (a sand bore) passage, to the Eastward of Long-Key; but on seeing the Merlin beating into the harbor of St. George's Key, and that our fleet was reinforced by the armed vessels Nos. 2 [sloop 'Tickler'] and 3 [sloop 'Mermaid'], and a large gun-boat, they returned to their former anchorage between Long Key and Key-Chappel.* [69]

Practically in the nick of time high noon on 6th September the entire defensive flotilla forced O'Neil and Bocanegra to abandon their first strike at St. George's Caye and thereby revealed that their next move was most likely another direct attempt to take St. George's Caye by way of the "sand-bore passage" between the reef and the cayes. Still, Barrow was of the opinion that:

> *the enemy would alter his mode of attack, and endeavour to make a landing on the main land to the northward of our posts, at the Haul-over. Under this idea I meant to embark with 200 men, including detachments of His majesty's 63rd and 6th West India regiments, and of the Royal Artillery, with one howitzer and two field-pieces, six-pounders. With this force it was my intention to block up the channel between the main and western point of Hick's Keys, and to obstruct as much as possible a landing in that quarter; or, if foiled in both of these objects, to throw the whole strength into the works at the Haul-over, and to defend that post to the last extremity; while a body of experienced bush-men, all good shots, and under orders for that purpose, should hang on the flanks and rear of the enemy...* [70]

It was a good plan never to be put to the test.

For the next three days, while Barrow and his troops took up position at Forts Lindsay and Balcarres located at the "Haulover" or proper mouth of the Belize River, Moss and the flotilla closely watched the armada "working and

anchoring among the shoals…at the distance of three or four miles." [71] This placed the armada just east of Long Caye and confirmed slow movement towards the south, failure to find a way out through the cayes and shoals, and another strike at St. George's Caye. At best the Spaniards were poorly prepared for the final confrontation.

Friction between O'Neil and Bocanegra burst into flame during their pre-battle preparations. Bocanegra was ordered to

> *take command of the Spanish flotilla, and that all of the armed forces involved in war, including the schooner "Ricardo" on which O'Neil was travelling, should go to confront the enemy: but Bocanegra refused to take charge of the action, as he did with respect to the idea of the head schooner taking part in the action, under the pretext that it was responsible for the convoy and it should remain behind with him.*[72]

This treasonous disobedience should have earned Bocanegra a firing squad. Instead, O'Neil's rather weak response was to call "a meeting of naval officers in which he confirmed the order to attack the enemy."[73] Although the officers unanimously accepted that order, Bocanegra still persisted in his disobedience, forcing O'Neil to appoint the less-experienced Don Pedro Grajales to direct the engagement. [74] Without the firepower of their flagship "Ricardo," and with a serious break in the chain of command, the Spaniards proposed to finally overcome the defensive flotilla that had kept them bottled up for the past seven days. Early on Monday morning, 10th September,

> *fourteen of the largest vessels…weighed anchor, and at nine o'clock brought to about a mile and a half distant from our fleet…Nine of them got under weigh about noon: These carried each two twenty-four-pounders in the bow, and two eighteen-pounders in the stern; one schooner carried twenty-two, and all the rest from eight to fourteen guns in the waist; and every one of them, besides being crowded with men, towed a large launch, full of soldiers. The other five vessels, with several large launches, all full of men, remained at this last anchorage at the distance of a mile and a half.*[75]

O'Neil and Grajales blundered badly for the last time. The narrow funnel or bottle neck between Frenchman's Shoals and the reef through which they proposed to squeeze nine behemoths, heavily armed, laden with troops, and towing open launches crammed with even more troops was a perfect killing zone for the defenders.

The defensive formation designed by Moss made maximum use of the narrow, shallow confines of the funnel:

Our fleet was drawn up with his Majesty's ship Merlin in the

> *centre, and directly abreast of the channel. The sloops with heavy guns, and the gun-boats in some advance to the Northward, were on the Eastern and Western flanks.*[76]

Hence *"Merlin's"* long-range main guns pointed directly at the center of the line of advancing battleships and troop-laden launches. To the east and slightly north or ahead of *"Merlin,"* the sloops and schooners controlled the deeper waters next to the reef. To the west and slightly north or ahead of *"Merlin,"* the agile gun-boats, propelled by slaves, dominated the shoal over which the Spanish vessels could not pass. It was a virtually impenetrable "V"-shaped formation or wide open jaw with ferocious firepower.

Into this barrier "the enemy came down in a very handsome manner, and with a good countenance, in a line abreast, using both sails and oars." [77] Throughout their slow but deliberate progress Moss's guns were silent until "at half-past one p.m. seeing their intention to board the two sloops, and that they meant to come no nearer, but had anchored, I made the signal to engage, which began and continued near two hours…"[78] For two hours the flotilla pressed the attack, all guns blazing, cannon balls finding easy targets among the high hulls crammed into the narrow channel with no room to maneuver and incapable of delivering effective broadsides while at anchor and towing launches. For the soldiers exposed in the launches this must have been a hellish experience. To lookouts perched on roof-tops on the mainland "the atmosphere appeared in a blaze."[79] Broadside after broadside blasted from the "Merlin" and its gallant companions ripped into the bowels of the overcrowded Spanish hulls and reaped a grim harvest of death and destruction. Captain Moss recorded in his report on the battle that "the spirit of the Negro slaves that manned our small crafts was wonderful."[80] Coming from the laconic Moss, this was the highest praise. On the other hand, when cannon balls flew, Potts, Lawrie and other members of the pro-evacuation faction were out of harm's way on the mainland.

Before he gave the signal to attack, Moss hastily wrote a letter summoning Barrow from his forts at the Haulover. Barrow reported that:

> *At half past three in the afternoon, I received a letter from Capt. Moss stating that the enemy was preparing to attack him, and requiring all the assistance which I could give. I immediately ordered as many men to embark and proceed to his assistance, as small craft to carry them could be procured. The alacrity shown on this occasion was great indeed, but as a requisition of this nature was by no means expected, the necessary arrangements had not been made for so speedily embarking the troops, and of consequence some irregularity ensued; for the cannonade being distinctly heard, and a certainty of an engagement having taken place, it became impossible to restrain the eagerness of the Colonial troops, who, possessing*

> *canoes, dories, and pit pans, without thought or retrospect of those left behind, hastened with impetuosity to join their companions, and share their danger…As soon as I saw seventeen craft of different descriptions, having on board two hundred men, set off with orders to rally round the Merlin, I immediately joined them in hopes of assisting Capt. Moss and harassing the enemy; but although we were only two hours in getting aboard the Merlin…we were too late to have any share in the action…*[81]

The fury of the firefight and the terrible harvest it was reaping spread havoc among the attackers. O'Neil and Grajales, both of whom were aboard open launches, witnessed the heartbeat of their "magnificent expedition" being extinguished by a single battleship firing eight-gun broadsides that drew no effective response from the nine attackers. The *"Merlin's"* forward and flanking flotilla of small vessels with "heavy metal," manned for the most part by slaves, made the defensive barrage a rolling thunder of death. Spanish soldiers were being slaughtered without even a chance of engaging in the land battle for which they had been trained. Loss of any of the ships meant more overcrowding on the surviving vessels already infested with yellow fever. Barrow opined that the sight of his seventeen crafts "full of men coming up with velocity, hastened the return of the enemy."[82] Grajales was fearful of having the Caye Chapel exit being cut off by being "attacked from the rear."[83]

Under those circumstances Grajales inevitably "placed a signal of retreat on his ship."[84] The Spaniards responded by breaking off the engagement with disastrous haste when "they cut their cables and rowed and towed off by signal in great confusion over the shoals"[85] where some of the ships were grounded. Upon seeing the frantic efforts of the Spaniards to withdraw, having to use their launches to tow those ships that were grounded, the slaves

> *"who manned the fleets, gave a hearty cheer, and in the midst of firing of grape [shot] kept up upon them from the Spanish vessels that covered those which were aground,…in an undaunted manner rowed their boats, and used every exertion to board the enemy; but Captain Moss, who directed everything, called back the flats (from motives of prudence) first by signal and then by sending a boat…"*[86]

Once again the gallantry of the slaves stood out in these lines penned by an anonymous author who recorded the events in a letter published by the Jamaica "Royal Gazette" of 3rd November, 1798.

Moss was justifiably prudent in recalling his flotilla. Daylight was turning into night. Pursuit of the mortally-wounded Spaniards within the shallow confines of the corridor where the *"Merlin"* could not venture would have been disastrous for the small crafts as the Spaniards had enough cannons left to defend themselves. So far the defenders had sustained neither casualties[87]

nor, in Barrow's own words, damages "done to any of our vessels, deserving of notice." [88] On the other hand, the Spaniards "suffered much…as well in killed and wounded as in the hulls and rigging of the vessels engaged."[89] Further confirmation of Spanish casualties is provided by Captain Edwards's report that some of the defenders "visited Key-Chappel, where the Spaniards had rendezvoused, and found it covered with graves, but whether they contained the bodies of those who fell in the attack, or of those who had fallen victims to the flux [yellow fever]…could not be ascertained…"[90]

Such was the naval engagement erroneously characterized by Shoman as "one which the Spaniards were bound to lose, given their situation; one that hardly saw any military confrontation."[91] These interpretations are not supported by the evidence. It was not so much that the Spaniards were bound to lose, but that the inhabitants had to win, or suffer annihilation, together with legitimization by force of arms of Spanish sovereignty tenuously bequeathed by Tordesillas and subsequent Anglo-Spanish treaties, and the final incorporation of the Honduras Settlement into the Spanish colonial domains. In truth, the Spaniards had nothing to lose other than their lives and their dignity. They had never possessed, other than by the dubious claim of Tordesillas, the area now called Belize. Thanks in no small measure to the resilience of the inhabitants, the century-long Spanish rivalry with Great Britain over Honduras never succeeded in uprooting the 'Baymen infestation,' in testimony of which the Spaniards left unmarked graves at Caye Chapel.

Those unmarked graves validated Moss's skillful strategy of denying the Spaniards even the slightest chance of bringing their troops to bear in what could have been, for the defenders, a disastrous land battle. Post-tenth events vindicated Moss's prudence in terminating the firefight when he did. On the 11th, *"Merlin"* and its companions, including Barrow's seventeen crafts, were again in position east of St. George's Caye when they were joined by "two armed ships, the 'Juba' and 'Columbia'" which Barrow "had ordered round to St. George's Key on the 9th."[92] Reinforcement of the defensive flotilla appeared to have "induced the fleet to prepare for returning to their respective posts. The Spaniards remained under Key-Chappel until the 15th, on the morning of which they made various movements, and in the course of the day some of them anchored under Key-Caulker. On the morning of the 16th, it was discovered that they had stolen off; eight of their largest vessels got out to sea and stood to the Northward; the remainder…shaped their course for Bacalar…"[93] From Bacalar, the rest of O'Neil's troops his intended army of occupation struggled overland to Merida and Campeche, "sufriendo la mayoria de la gente en el camino los horrore de la fiebre amarilla."[94] O'Neil's awesome armada was thoroughly thrashed. There would be no further attempt by Spain to remove the British thorn in its side at Yucatan, but this the inhabitants did not know.

What they did know was that they could not relax their vigilance in case the Spaniards decided to make another attempt. With this in mind, on 13th September Barrow sent out two scout dories manned by Captains Meighan, O'Connor and Courtenay

> *With orders to pass the Spanish fleet in the night, and proceeding to the northward, to board the first small vessel they could fall in with. On the 16th they captured a small packet-boat with five hands, when, taking out the prisoners, letters, etc. and destroying the boat they returned here [the settlement] on the 17th. At day-light of that day the canoes were entangled with the retreating Spanish fleet near Savanna-Quay [Caye], and escaped with difficulty.*[95]

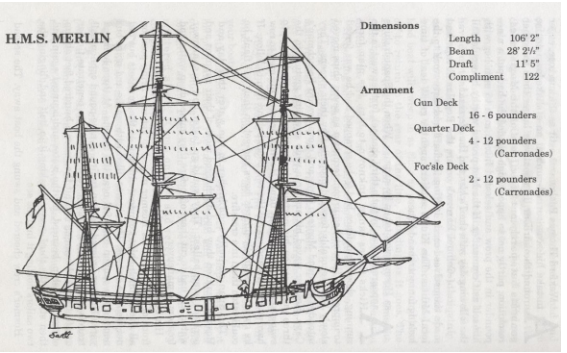
Moss recorded that "so certain were the Spaniards of success, that the letters found in [the] canoe taken were actually directed to Belize and St. George's Key."[96] The prisoners themselves confirmed the presence of 3,000 reserve troops at Bacalar, waiting for "when the first part could effect a landing at St. George's Key, and send vessels to bring them back."[97] There could be no doubt that Spain's intention was not just to conclude its century-old quest to wipe out the "mere usurpations by lawless pirates," but also to permanently plant the Spanish flag at St. George's Caye and Haulover.

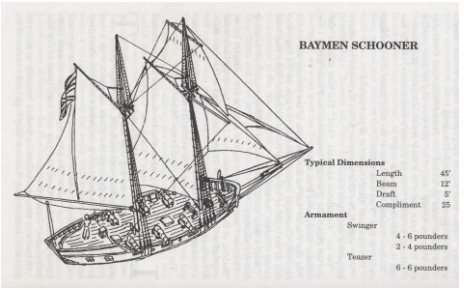
Instead, the Union Jack continued to fly over a desperately impoverished settlement where the inhabitants were soon forced to declare that:

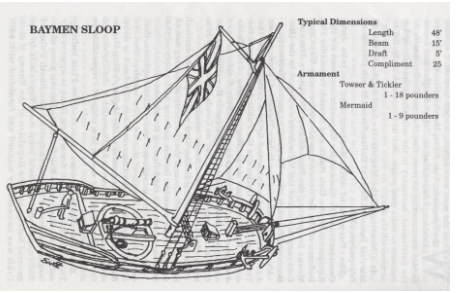
> *their exertion for the last two months in repelling a Spanish invasion have put a punishing hand to their resources both public and private, and that they feel themselves in consequence thereof compelled to avow that any protection afforded to this Settlement in its present state short of a complete assumption of every part of the expense which may be found necessary for its effectual protection and defence in the event of the continuation of war with Spain will only tend by slower degrees to bring ruin and destruction of His Majesty's subjects settled here…*[98]

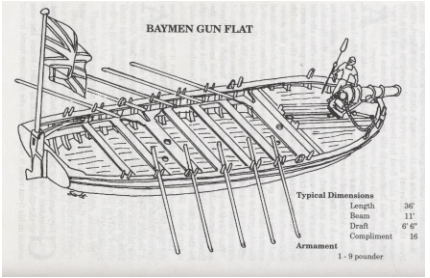
Those worst fears of "ruin and destruction" did not materialize. The century-old Anglo-Spanish duel over the settlement was finished. In the aftermath of the battle, the settlement's permanence was confirmed, and British sovereignty was consolidated by way of the Superintendent. Balcarres's revival of the superintendency was not only decisive; it altered the settlement's political structure.

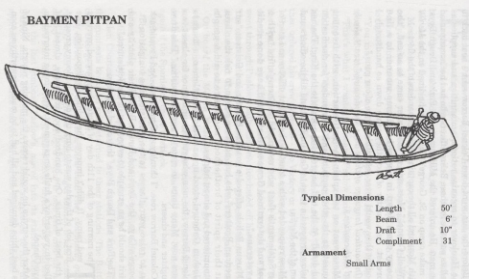
The winds of war which blew Barrow into the settlement also set in motion the political processes which by 1871 transformed the settlement into the Crown Colony of British Honduras. One hundred and ten years thereafter, the Nationalist Movement triumphed with the attainment of Independence. Indeed, "the Battle of St. George's Caye forever changed the path of Belizean history."

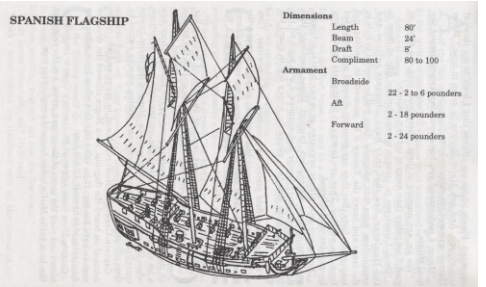












Source: King, Emory. The Great story of Belize Vol. 1

NOTES

Abbreviations: BARS - Belize Archives and Records Service, Belmopan
CO - Colonial Office Records, Public Records Office, London
ADM - Admiralty Records, PRO, London

1. Jared C. Lobdell (ed.), "At the Mouth of the Belize: Three Letters from Thomas Dundas to Henry Dundas, later Lord Melville, December 16, 1796 June 15, 1797," in *The Journal of Caribbean History*, Vol. 19: 1 (Kingston: The UWI Press, 1984), 77. All three letters were written aboard "His Majesty's Sloop Merlin" at "Belize Rivers Mouth."
2. Ibid, 78; CO 137/98, Barrow to Balcarres, 17th January, 1797.
3. Ibid, 79.
4. Mavis C. Campbell, "St. George's Cay: Genesis of the British Settlement of Belize Anglo Spanish Rivalry," in *The Journal of Caribbean History*, Vol. 37: 2 (Kingston: The University of the West Indies Press, 2003), 178, as quoted from Don Juan de Villagutierre Soto-Mayor, History of the Conquest of the Itza (California: Labyrinthas Press, 1983), 215. See also Aloin Breton and Michael Antochiew, *Cartographic Catalogue of Belize*, 1511 1880 (Mexico: Bureau Regional de Cooperation en America Centrale, 1992), 52. This account is well documented from Spanish sources and asserts that "Yucatecans successfully managed to dislodge the English from Cayo Cocinas in 1695 96," but that the island "was abandoned, leaving an open door for the English to return."
5. Campbell, "St. George's Cay," 185.
6. Jose Antonio Calderon Quijano, *Belice, 1663 (?) 1821: Historia de los establicimientos britanicos del Rio Valis hasta la independencia de Hispanoamerica* (Seville: University of Seville, 1944), 353.
7. John A. Burdon (ed.), *Archives of British Honduras*, Volume I (London: Sifton Praed, 1931), 216 (Magistrates to Rear Admiral Hyde Parker, Jamiaca, March 22, 1796)
8. Lobdell, "At the Mouth," 84, 85.
9. Epitaph on the tomb of Thomas Potts, at St. George's Caye Cemetery, Belize's oldest post-Maya civilization cemetery; recorded in John Purcell Usher, *Memorial Inscriptions and Epitaphs* (Belize City: 1907), 48.
   Potts' monumental sarcophagus, depicted on the five-dollar bill, has mysteriously disappeared from the cemetery. Hopefully current archaeological work on SGC will eventually lead to the recovery of this previous artifact said to have been buried after Hurricane Hattie (1961)

on pirate property adjoining the cemetery.

10. Campbell, "St. George's Cay," 192.
11. Ibid
12. Lobdell, "At the Mouth," 86.
13. Ibid, 82.
14. Ibid, 86, 87.
15. CO 137/98, Barrow to Balcarres, 16th June, 1797.
16. Burdon, *Archives* I, 236; CO 137/98, Balcarres to Barrow, 28th August, 1797.
17. Ibid
18. Ibid
19. Ibid, 237.
20. BARS, Minutes of a Public Meeting, 16th September, 1797.
21. Lobdell, "At the Mouth," 80.
22. Burdon, *Archives* I, 238.
23. Ibid, 242.
24. Ibid, 244.
25. Ibid, 245.
26. Ibid
27. Richard Buhler, "How the British won the Battle of St. George's Caye," in *Belizean Studies*, Vol. 7: 5 (Belize City: St. John's College, September, 1979).
28. Calderon Quijano, *Belice*, 353.
29. Ibid
30. Buhler, "How the British," 4.
31. CO 137/100; Barrow to Balcarres, 11 August, 1798.
32. Calderon Quijano, *Belice*, 354.
33. Buhler, "How the British," 5.
34. Burdon, *Archives* I, 261. This document, Barrow to Balcarres, 23 September, 1798, could not be found in CO 137/101. Also recorded in Monrad Metzgen, Shoulder to Shoulder or the Battle of St. George's Caye, 1998 (Belize City, 1428) 15 19.
35. Ibid
36. Buhler, "How the British," 5.
37. Burdon, *Archives* I, 245 46.
38. Buhler, "How the British," 3.
39. BARS, Minutes of a Public Meeting, 20 July, 1798.
40. Ibid
41. O. Nigel Bolland, *The Formation of a Colonial Society: Belize from*

Conquest to Crown Colony (Baltimore and London: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1977), 50.

42. Lobdell, "At the Mouth," 81.
43. Ibid, 84.
44. BARS, Minutes of a Public Meeting, 21st July, 1798
45. Burdon, *Archives I*, 248, 249 (verbatim).
46. Ibid, 249.
47. Ibid
48. CO 137/100, Thomas Potts and 52 other Baymen to Thomas Barrow, 20th August, 1798; forwarded to Balcarres.
49. BARS, Magistrates to Barrow, 8th August, 1798; Barrow to Magistrates, 9th August, 1798; Burdon, *Archives* I, 250.
50. Burdon, *Archives* I, 260; Barrow to Balcarres, 23rd September, 1798.
51. Ibid, 257; ADM 1/248, Moss to Vice-Admiral Sir Hyde Parker, 27th September, 1798.

    A drawing of the 'Merlin," done by former British Deputy High Commissioner, Mr. Lamport from original shipyard drawings held by the National Maritime Museum in London, is on display at the House of Culture/Government House. Further technical details about the "ship that won the Battle" may be found in William James, *Naval History of Great Britain* II, New Edition (London: 1837), 249

    The Bi-centennial commemorative stamps, here reproduced, best illustrate the Baymen's fleet and the Spanish flagship "Ricardo."
52. Campbell, "St. George's Caye," 193.
53. Burdon, *Archives* I, 251 (verbatim).
54. Ibid, 257.
55. Ibid, 253.
56. Ibid, 252, 257.
57. Buhler, "How the British," 6.
58. Burdon, *Archives* I, 260.
59. Ibid, 257.
60. Ibid; ADM 1/248: Moss to Admiral Sir Hyde Parker, 27th September, 1798.
61. Ibid
62. Ibid, 253.
63. Ibid, 257.
64. Ibid, ADM 1/248.
65. Ibid
66. Ibid, 257 258.

67. Ibid, 258.
68. ADM 1/248.
69. Burdon, *Archives* I, 258; ADM 1/248, in which Moss wrote that he "secured" SGC when "they (the Spaniards) hauled their wind and returned to Long-Key, on my hauling my wind towards them."
70. Burdon, *Archives*, I, 258.
71. ADM, 1/248.
72. Juan Francisco Molina Solis, *Historia de Yucatan durante la dominación española*, III (Merida: Imprenta de la Loteria del Estado, 1904 1913), 342.
73. Ibid, 342, 343.
74. Ibid
75. ADM 1/248.
76. Burdon, *Archives* I, 245.
77. Ibid, 259.
78. Ibid, 262; ADM 1/248.
79. Ibid 255, anonymous letter dated September 25, 1798.
80. ADM 1/248/
81. Burdon, *Archives* I, 259 260; Barrow to Duke of Portland, September 23, 1798.
82. Ibid, 260.
83. Molina Solis, *Historia*, 345.
84. Ibid
85. ADM 1/248.
86. Burdon, *Archives* I, 255.
87. Ibid, 260; ADM 1/248.
88. Ibid
89. Ibid
90. Ibid, 253, Report of Capt. Edwards in the "Royal Gazette," Kingston, Jamaica, November 3, 1798.
91. Shoman, *Thirteen Chapters of a History of Belize* (Belize City: The Angelus Press Limited, 1994), 29.
92. Burdon, *Archives* I, 260.
93. Ibid
94. Calderon Quijano, *Belice*, 355 356.
95. Burdon, *Archives* I, 260 261.
96. ADM 1/248
97. *Archives* I, 255.
98. BARS, Minutes of a Public Meeting, September 24, 1798.

Birthplace of a Nation: The Archaeology of St. George's Caye, Belize

James F. Garber, Jaime J. Awe, and Lauren A. Sullivan

Abstract

St. George's Caye played a vital role in the history and development of Belize as an independent nation. The Battle of St. George's Caye on September 10, 1798 represents the end of Spain's attempts to conquer the territory that is now known as Belize. Although this battle happened over 200 years ago it still plays a significant role in Belizean culture, as seen during the annual September Celebrations when people all over the country honor the Battle St. George's Caye. The Caye is also featured on the Belize five-dollar bill. While much has been written about the history of St. Georges Caye, the first capital of Belize, there has been little archaeology done on the island. With this in mind, the authors began conducting archival research and interviewing landowners in order to begin a historic archaeology project focused on St. Georges Caye.

St. George's Caye is one of hundreds of islands off the coast of Belize that are part of a large reef system, the second largest in the world. Although St. George's Caye is small, its position and shape caused it to play a predominant role in the early history of the English settlement that was to become known as Belize. The reef system forms an offshore barrier that protects the coast. Because of the difficulties of navigation, these waters provided safe haven for merchants, buccaneers, and pirates that sailed the Caribbean. To access the mainland and harbors at the mouths of the rivers, one must navigate narrow passages through the reef and then follow a complex system of channels. To reach the Belize River, the country's main river system, one must pass by St. George's Caye, thus it's strategic location guarding the port (Figure 1). Additionally, the Caye is crescent shaped making it ideal for careening ships on its leeward side (Figure 2).

THE 1600S - EARLY HISTORY AND INITIAL ENGLISH SETTLEMENT

By the mid 1600s English pirates, buccaneers, and merchants were sailing the waters off the coast of Belize. Although the Spanish had settled areas to the north, west, and south, they did not attempt to establish a settlement in Belize. In 1677 Spanish Fray Jose Delgado and a small party were passing through Belize on their way to Bacalar and were captured by English pirates along the coast a few miles south of Belize City. They were taken to their leader, the infamous English pirate, Bartholomew Sharpe who was temporarily headquartered on St. George's Caye (Delgado 1677; Thompson 1988:41). The priest and his party stayed on the Caye for a while, were treated well, and then taken to the north and released unharmed.

Figure 1

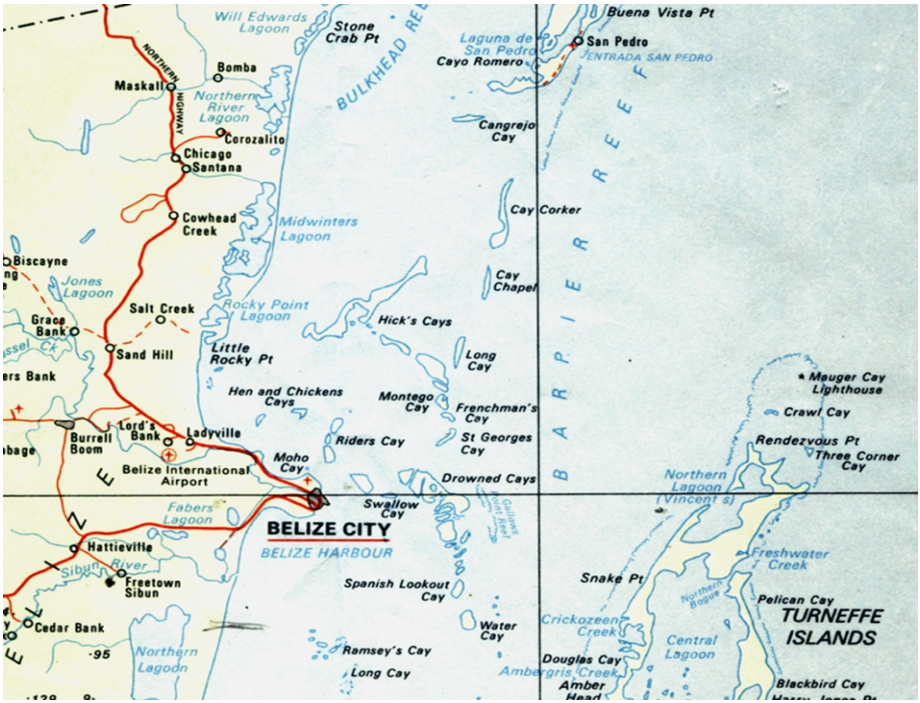


Figure 2



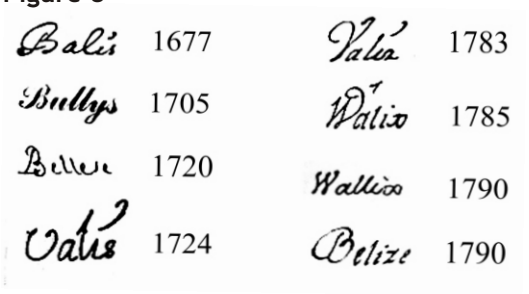
During the late 1600's English woodcutters, or Baymen as they are known, settled on St. George's Caye and at the mouth of the Belize River. The settlement, that eventually becomes known as Belize, has no official name at this time but appears in the various records as: English Settlement on the Bay of Honduras; English Settlement at the mouth of the River Walix; Settlement of English Woodcutters in the Bay of Honduras; English Settlement of Honduras; and The Bay Settlement.

ORIGIN OF THE NAME BELIZE

The beginnings of the Settlement on the Bay and the origin of the name "Belize" have been the subject of discussion and debate since the first written history of the Settlement (1826 Honduras Almanak). At times these debates have "stuck to the facts" and at others have strayed into the realm of legend. Listed here are the various spellings and dates for the variations of the name Belize (Figure 3): Balis (1677) in Fray Jose Delgados's journey to Bacalar; Bullys (1705) in a letter from John Fingas to the Council of Trade; Bellese (1720) in report of Captain Nathan Uring's voyage to Belize; Valis (1724) Report in Madrid of the number of English settlers; Valiz (1783) Spanish map showing "Rio de Valiz /Yngles River Bellese"; Balleze and Bellese (1786) map made by "a Bay Man" showing area allotted to Great Britain for the cutting of Logwood (Figure 4); Walix (1786) Spanish map showing logwood area occupied by the English settlers ; Wallix (1790) from a map by Rafael Llobet (map is labeled in Spanish); Belize (1790) in letter from Peter Hunter (Superintendent of the Bay Settlement) to Baltasar Rodruguis.

The "Wallace" Hypothesis

Figure 3

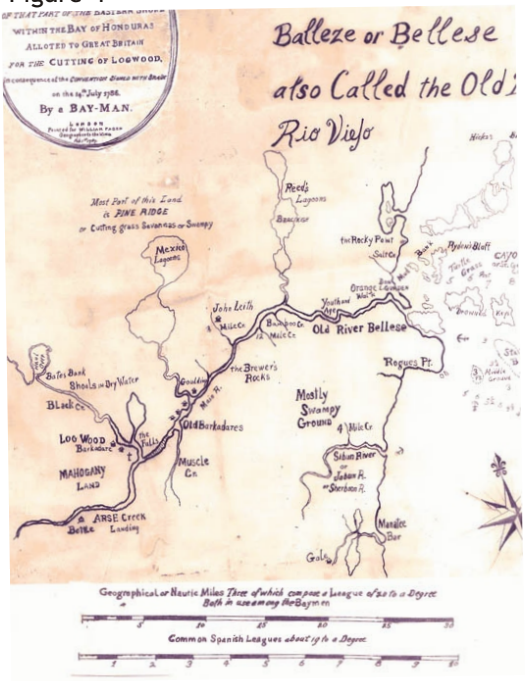


The notion that the name Belize came from someone named Wallice, Wallace, or Willis is first reported in the 1827 Honduras Almanak. Below is a passage from Sir John Burdon's Archives of British Honduras published in 1931 that summarizes these claims.

"In the 1827 Almanak the credit for discovering the mouth of the River Belize and making it his place of retreat is given to Wallice, a Lieutenant amongst the Buccaneers, from whose name 'Belize' is said to be derived. The 1839 Almanak gives the founder as the Scotch Corsair chief Wallace, native of Falkland in Kinross-shire, who, after being driven from Tortuga, erected huts and a fortilice at the spot called after him by the Spaniards 'Wallis' or 'Balis'.

Bridges (1828) states that Willis, the notorious Buccaneer and ex-

Figure 4



Governor of Tortuga, was the first Englishman to settle on the river, to which he gave his name. He dates this 1638, the year in which the Spaniards drove the Buccaneers out of Tortuga. Bancroft, 'History of Central America,' gives Peter Wallace, with 80 men, as the first settlers at Belize River. And finally, Francisco Asturias (1925) a Guatemalan historian, states that the Settlement was founded by Wallace, formerly Raleigh's First Lieutenant and right hand man, who, he says, is supposed to have first reached Belize in 1617." (Burdon 1931:2-3).

It is important to point out that a number of modern professional historians have noted that no documents dating to the 1600s have been referenced or produced to substantiate the claim that someone named Wallice, Wallace, or Willis was ever in Belize at this time.

The "Maya" Hypothesis

Starting in the 1950s several researchers have suggested that the name Belize has its origins in the Mayan language. A. H. Anderson, the first archaeological Commissioner of British Honduras suggests that the word Belize is a derived from the forgotten Maya name for the river (Anderson 1958:35). Sir J. Eric Thompson, noted Mayanist, states that Beliz in Yucatec Maya signifies muddy or muddy water (Thompson 1988:43 original manuscript presented to Belize 1970). Assad Shoman (1994) suggests the words Belakin (land towards the sea), Baltiz (land of the Itza) or Beliz (muddy waters). And finally, Emory King (1999) reports Belikin meaning land of muddy water.

It is important to note that the Diccionario Maya Cordemex, by far the most thorough dictionary of Yucatec Maya, does not list Beliz, Belakin, Baltiz, or Belikin. Maya words are composed of phonemes (vowel consonant combinations) and each can carry several meanings. Within the Cordemex dictionary one of the many meanings for "be" is muddy water and "bel ha" means canal or aqueduct. There is no historical record of the Maya referring to the Belize area by any of these names.

The "African" Hypothesis
David Hernandez (1990) suggests that the name Belize is an example of linguistic convergence in that slaves who came from the Cabinda Province of Angola were already familiar with the name as there is a river and village named Belize in that locale.

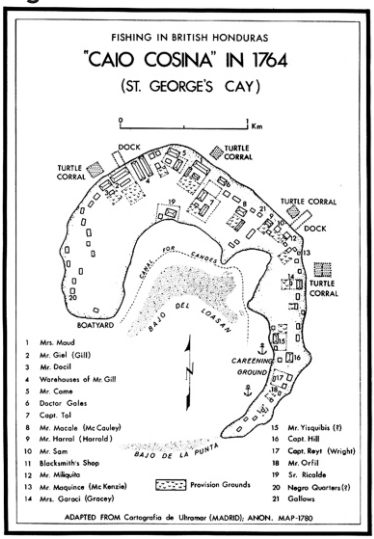
The "Bullys River - Rogues Point" Hypothesis
In a 1705 report to the Council of Trade in London, John Fingas notes the "River of Bullys" where the English load their logwood. A 1786 map of the Bay Settlement shows the present day location of Government House as "Rogues Point". Emory King (1999:9-10) implies that Rogue and Bully are approximate synonyms.

The "Spanish" Hypothesis
It is interesting to note that scholars have sought the origins for the word Belize in English, Mayan, and African languages. No published sources that we are aware of have suggested the origin to lie in the Spanish language. Several early Spanish maps show Spanish names for numerous locations within Belize. A search of an 18th century dictionary revealed an interesting possibility (Nuevo Tesoro Lexiconografico de la Lengua Espanola -1739). The word "valiza" (pronounced "baliza" and spelled "baliza" in later dictionaries) is a nautical term that refers to a marker placed by a canoe, or launch at the entrance of ports so that ships can enter by not touching shoals or shallows. In more recent dictionaries, the word "valais" refers to lumber. Either of these meanings would be appropriate. The first would be a logical nautical notation and the second would be a reasonable reference to the river mouth as it is clear from several sources that forest products were loaded at this location.
Throughout the 1600s English mariners (pirates, buccaneers, merchants) were sailing the waters off Belize and would have made landings on the cayes or mainland. However, we should note that most modern historians have rejected claims of English settlement in Belize prior to 1670 due to lack of evidence. We find it interesting that two of the earliest references to the River, "Balis" (Spanish reference in 1677) and "Bullys" (English reference in 1705) are the closest in spelling and pronunciation to "Belize" than many of the variations that follow in subsequent decades. No doubt the debate will continue as to the origin of the name Belize but we hope that the information listed above will be helpful in that discussion.

BURNABY'S CODE BELIZE'S FIRST CONSTITUTION
The 1700s witnessed continuous struggles between Britain and Spain. Spain claimed sovereignty over Belize but at times granted logging rights to English cutters. The English settlers were not permitted to have plantations or establish a government. In 1765 Admiral Burnaby was sent from Jamaica (by orders from London) to the settlement to look into disputes between the English woodcutters and the Spanish to the north in what is today Mexico.

While at St. George's Caye, the Baymen had Admiral Burnaby put into the King's English the code of law they had been operating under. This code was in part based on the democratic principles of pirate law of the sea. It became known as "Burnaby's Code" and was signed on April 9, 1765 on St. George's Caye by 85 Baymen including two women. Burnaby's Code served as the Belize's constitution from 1765 until 1862 when it became a British Colony (British Honduras).

Figure 5



A Spanish map of St. George's Caye from 1764 shows the location of properties, houses, gallows, etc (Figure 5). The English names of property owners are shown, but it is written by someone who only spoke Spanish, thus the names are awkward and misspelled. Interestingly, this map was made one year before the signing of Burnaby's Code and thus several of the signers should be shown on the map. As far as we know, no historians have ever made this connection. By comparing the awkward / misspelled names on the map with the list of those who signed Burnaby's Code, we have been able to make several matches and are now able to locate the houses and properties of several of Belize's founding fathers and mothers (Table 1).

THE BATTLE OF ST. GEORGE'S CAYE THE FIGHT FOR INDEPENDENCE

Although Burnaby's Code provided the basis for law and order in the settlement, it did not resolve the disputes with Spain. In 1779 the Spanish captured St. George's Caye and took approximately 350 of its inhabitants prisoner. Most, if not all, of those that were not taken prisoner fled the settlement. The prisoners were taken to Fort Bacalar (near Chetumal Mexico) and then marched to Merida, Yucatan. From there they were taken to Havana and imprisoned until their release in 1783. The settlement and the Cayes were later reoccupied by the Baymen. Tensions between Spain and Britain continued and it became clear that Spain intended to invade and retake the Bay Settlement. Remembering the horrors of imprisonment from the previous invasion, the Baymen assembled to make a decision as to whether they should evacuate or fight. In the largest public meeting held in the settlement up to that point the vote was taken. Fifty-one voted to evacuate and sixty-five voted to stay and fight. The deciding votes to stay and fight were cast by fourteen freed slaves (Burdon 1931:25).

In late August 1798, the Spanish assembled a sizeable flotilla to re-take Belize. It consisted of 31 warships, 2000 troops, and 500 sailors. The Baymen

defenses, meager by comparison, consisted of one British warship, the HMS Merlin; two private sloops, the Towser and the Tickler; two private schooners, the Swinger and the Teaser; and seven small gunflats. By all accounts, the Baymen were out-gunned and out-manned. Between September 3-10, 1798 the Spanish made several advances on St. George's Caye. Their their final advance was made on September 10. The battle lasted 2 ½ hours after which the Spanish fleet sailed off in defeat (Burdon 1931:27-28). It was Spain's last attempt to take Belize by force. Although outgunned and outmanned the Bayman defenses won out due to superior leadership, strategy, and knowledge of the shallow water and channels. The Spanish suffered from poor leadership, inadequate knowledge of the channels and shoals, poor strategy, and illness (yellow fever and the flux had swept through the Spanish force).

CONCLUSION

he Battle of St. George's Caye forever changed the path of Belizean history. The self-governing settlement attracted groups of various ethnicities that, even today, give Belize a multicultural feel which distinguishes it from surrounding countries. It is our hope to recover and document the archaeological remains associated with events before and after the historic battle. The project will include continued archival research, documenting artifacts collected by landowners, excavations, as well as underwater archaeology. In the end, our goal is to shed new light on one of the most significant periods in the early development of the modern nation of Belize.

Table 1. Possible matches between 1764 map and 1765 signers of Burnaby's Code

1764 Map Names	Burnaby's Code Signers
Mr. Giel	Nehemiah Gale
Capt. Reyt	William Wyatt
Mr. Orfil	John Oliver
Mr. Harrol	James Ferrall
Mr. Yisquibis	D. Fitzgibbons
Mr. Come	Benjamin Bascome
Mr. Sam	Andrew Slumen
Mr. Ricalde	Thomas Roblie
Mr. Tol	William Dal
Mrs. Maud	John Maud
Capt. Hill	Mary Wil

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1739

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Thompson, Sir J. Eric
1988 The Maya of Belize: Historical Chapters Since Columbus. Benque Viejo del Carmen, Belize. Cubola Productions.Figure Captions

Figure 1. Area map Belize City and Cayes
Figure 2. Satellite photo of St. George's Caye
Figure 3. Variations of “Belize”
Figure 4. 1786 Logwood cutting treaty map made by a “Bay Man”.
Figure 5. 1764 Spanish map of St. George's Caye (Cayo Cosina)

Notes